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Insurance: Implications From the Conflict With Iran

Key Takeaways

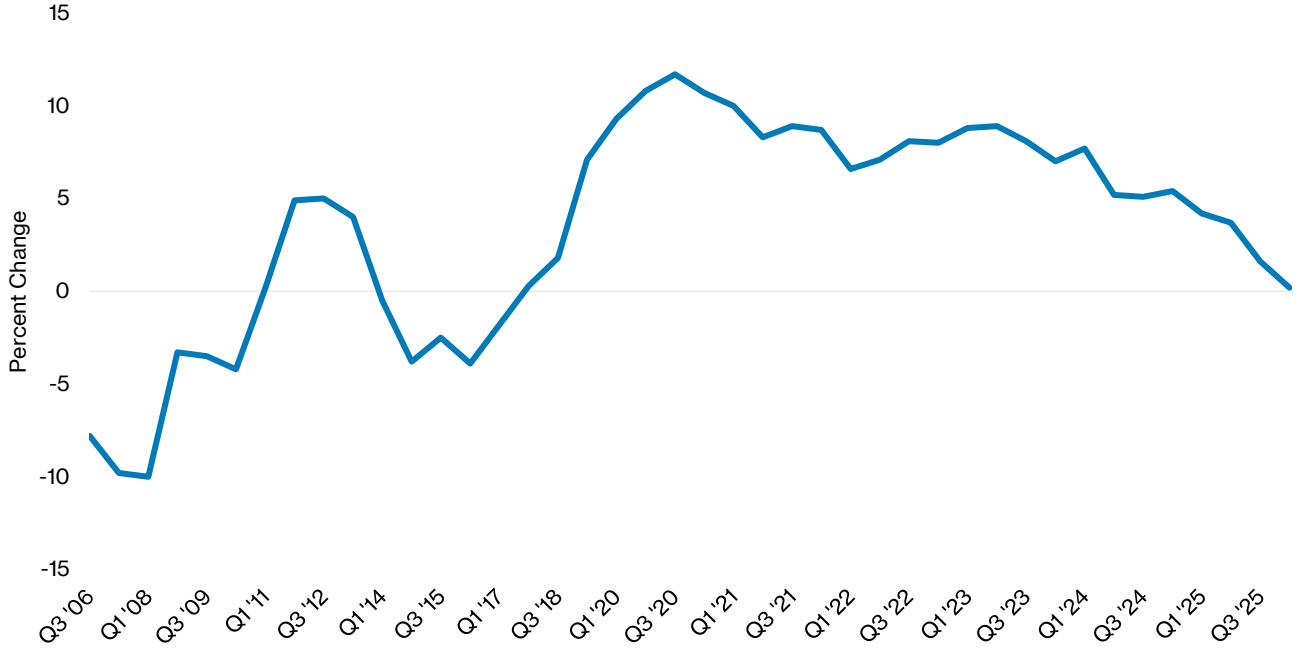
Positive (+) or Negative (-) Implications
(+) American International Group Inc. (AIG)
(+) Chubb Limited (CB)
(+) The Hartford Insurance Group Inc. (HIG)
(-) Berkshire Hathaway Inc. (BRK.B)
(-) The Travelers Companies Inc. (TRV)

- CFRA believes investors in the insurance space should focus on two key points related to the conflict with Iran: the degree to which marine insurance coverage availability (or lack thereof) will impact the oil markets and the broader economy, and the degree to which this event causes the insurance pricing environment to "harden."
- We expect the inflationary pressures and elevated geopolitical risks in the aftermath of the conflict with Iran will be more impactful to U.S. insurers than the potential claims from the actual conflict, since war exclusions are likely to be activated in most impacted policies.
- Among U.S. primary insurers, **AIG**, **BRK.B**, **CB**, **HIG**, and **TRV** have the most exposure to lines of coverage possibly exposed to this event, but CFRA views their exposures as manageable.

Fundamental Context

Pricing in the property-casualty (p-c) insurance market was "softening," but the conflict with Iran could tighten pricing. As Figure 1 illustrates, the p-c commercial lines market ended 2025 on a weak note, with average price increases of less than 1% in Q4 2025.

Figure 1: Average Quarterly Commercial Insurance Lines Rate Increases (2006-2025)



Source: Council of Insurance Agents and Brokers (www.ciab.com).

Market conditions were very different when the last major conflict erupted. Insurance market conditions were already tight coming out of the pandemic (with commercial insurance rate increases averaging nearly 9%) just before Russia invaded Ukraine on February 24, 2022. Conditions remained tight, and quarterly rate increases averaged between 7% and 9% for the next couple of years. Current market conditions are much softer, with average rate hikes of less than 1%. Consequently, we do not expect this conflict will cause market pricing to "turn" the way a major hurricane or some other far-reaching natural catastrophe might – partly due to the war exclusions that exist in many types of policies. At this juncture, we view the risk of demand destruction if the global economy weakens amid the expected rise in oil prices as a bigger threat. However, we expect this conflict to exert upward pressure on pricing, demand, and terms and conditions in the lines of coverage exposed to this event. In Figure 2, we highlight the lines of coverage most likely to be impacted.

Figure 2: Lines of Coverage Most Likely to Be Impacted by the Iranian Conflict

Marine Insurance

Hull & Machinery

- Covers vessels
- War risk premiums can raise premium rates from 0.025% of hull value to 0.5% of hull value
- Applies to vessels traveling in the Persian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz, and Gulf of Oman

Cargo

- Separate war risk coverage required for goods
- Rates increase 10x-50x during active conflict

Marine Liability

- Protection & indemnity (P&I) insurance
- Includes war risks
- Typically written by mutual insurers also known as P&I Clubs

Loss of Hire

- Business interruption for vessels unable to transit key routes
- Diversions around Africa add time and cost

Other Lines of Impacted Coverage

- Aviation – for both physical and liability risks and costly interruptions
- Political Risk – covers expropriation, political violence, contract frustration, currency issues
- Energy – covers offshore and onshore oil/gas platforms/facilities, sabotage, business interruption
- Trade credit – for non-payment risk and supply chain disruption
- Cyber – Iran has a history of cyber retaliation; claim disputes likely amid war exclusions
- Directors & Officers Liability
- Contingent business interruption

Source: CFRA.

Figure 3: Leading Insurers in Core Impacted Lines

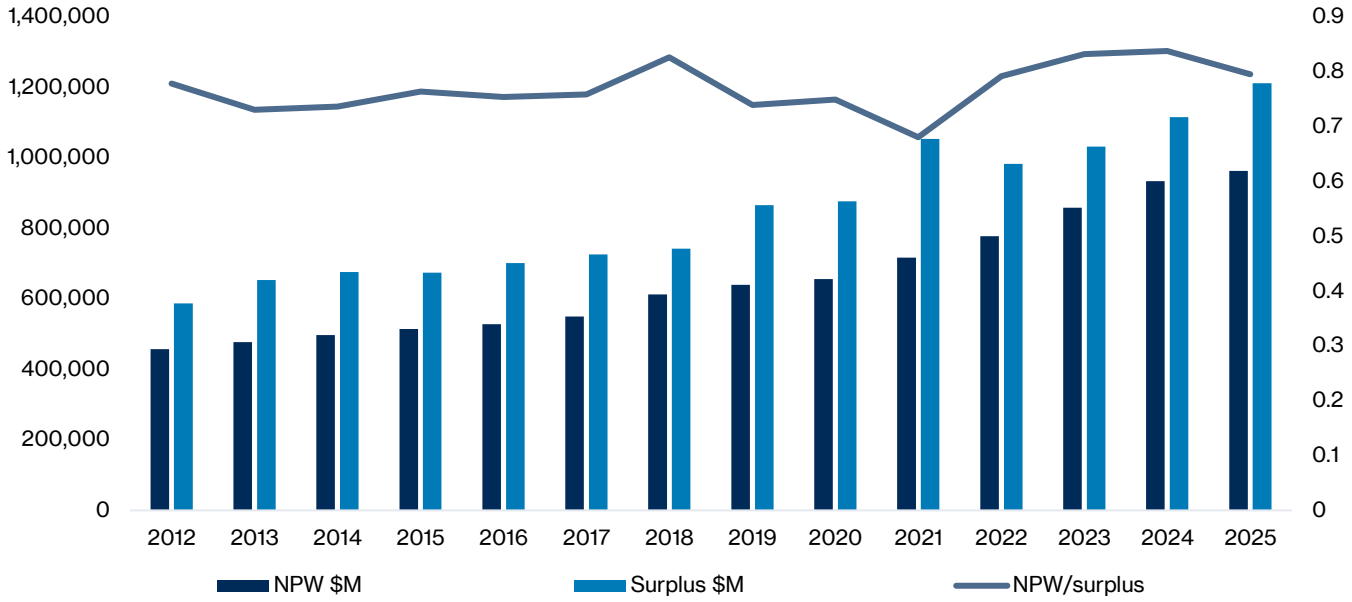
Firm	Market Share Ocean Marine	Market Share Inland Marine
American International Group Inc.	13.6%	4.4%
Starr Companies	7.8%	1.5%
Chubb Limited	6.6%	5.4%
Tokio Marine Holdings Inc.	6.5%	1%
The Travelers Companies Inc.	6.2%	2.9%
Berkshire Hathaway Inc.	4.9%	1.7%
The Hartford Insurance Group Inc.	4.0%	0.8%
Great American Insurance Group	3.9%	1.4%
CNA Financial Corporation	3.5%	8.4%
Intact Financial Corporation	2.7%	1%

Source: S&P Global Market Intelligence.

AIG tops the leaderboard in ocean marine coverage, and may also have exposure via aviation, political risk, energy, trade credit, cyber, and certain liability coverage it offers, though we note its exposure to this region is carefully managed. While AIG is a top ocean marine carrier and has a reputation for being able to write large complex risks, we note ocean marine coverage only accounts for 3% to 5% of AIG's $24 billion commercial lines insurance written premium base. In recent years, AIG also has lowered the risk profile of its book of business, partly through the sale of several of its reinsurance units that have political risk coverage exposure.

While it is too early to estimate what total insured losses from this conflict and the attendant economic fallout will be, we think there are several points for investors to consider now. First, we estimate direct exposure to Iran accounts for a very small (less than 2%) percentage of premium bases for the U.S.-based insurers in our coverage universe. Second, many standard lines of coverage (e.g., commercial property and business interruption) have explicit war exclusions. Other lines of coverage (e.g., cargo, aviation, and marine) contain provisions for a "war risk premium," or a surcharge to the existing policy that is automatically implemented to cover the additional risks of transporting and traveling within hostile territories. We expect the exposure the insurers in our coverage universe have to this region will primarily be in cyber, political risk cover, aviation, marine, and energy. Finally, the U.S.-domiciled insurance industry has ample capital to sustain these claims and remains underleveraged. As Figure 4 highlights, insurers ended 2025 with more than $1.2 trillion of surplus supporting a written premium base of around $963 billion, writing about $0.79 of business for every $1.00 of capital on their books. This broadly leaves the p-c insurance industry with an estimated $300 billion (or more) of so-called excess capital, an ample cushion to soften the blow of Iran-driven claims.

Figure 4: Property-Casualty Net Written Premiums to Surplus (2012-2025)



Source: S&P Global Market Intelligence.

A U.S. government-sponsored reinsurance plan was just introduced, which may miss the mark. On Friday, March 6, 2026, the Trump administration announced plans to provide up to $20 billion in reinsurance coverage for oil tankers and other commercial ships in the Persian Gulf region. This move is designed primarily to restart maritime traffic passing through the Strait of Hormuz, which has come to a standstill when insurers refused to provide coverage for ships (hull and cargo) once the conflict with Iran started (though Lloyd's of London claimed there was coverage available).

The plan, established under the auspices of the U.S. International Development Finance Corporation (DFC), outlined the following guidelines:

- The DFC reinsurance facility will insure losses up to approximately $20 billion on a rolling basis.
- This revolving insurance offering will apply only to vessels that meet the criteria.
- Insurance will focus on hull & machinery and cargo to start.
- The DFC has identified best-in-class, preferred American insurance partners.
- The DFC and Treasury are coordinating closely with CENTCOM on next steps in the implementation of this plan.

Our concern with this plan is that it is being structured as a reinsurance transaction, meaning primary insurers would have to absorb a certain amount of losses before the reinsurance kicks in and that amount has not yet been disclosed. Also, it is not clear to us whether this will be structured on a retroactive (i.e., covering losses that have already occurred) or prospective (only covering future losses) basis. We are also not sure that $20 billion is an adequate level of protection to entice enough insurers back into this market.

Conclusion and Investment Thesis

The shares of most p-c insurers will likely remain under pressure in the near term due to concerns surrounding the level of insured losses likely to emerge from the conflict in Iran, some concentrated risk in certain lines of coverage, and the rising inflation threat. However, CFRA believes that losses from this event could serve as a catalyst to help harden the current competitive pricing environment and provide the shares with a catalyst. We also think shares of AIG and HIG are likely to benefit from restructuring actions underway

at both firms, while the market leader CB is well positioned to leverage opportunities for growth amid a "flight to quality" among underwriters that usually occurs when market conditions become more competitive. We applaud TRV's underwriting acumen, but think its shares are fairly valued versus historical levels. Our Hold recommendation on BRK.B shares reflects our tempered view of this conglomerate's shares amid some weakening fundamentals.

Risk Factors

Risks to our thesis and recommendations include a significant downturn in world economies amid negative fallout from this conflict, coupled with a prolonged downturn in equity markets. There is also a risk that insured losses from this conflict exceed our initial loss estimates, and that the risk concentration from this event adversely impacts some of the leading insurers, particularly AIG and CB, which most likely have the greatest exposure to this event among publicly-traded insurers in our coverage universe.

Company Implications

American International Group Inc. (AIG 78 ****) entered 2026 having completed most of the heavy lifting of its restructuring that centered around the deconsolidation of its life insurance unit. AIG's go-forward operations consist of its North American Commercial, International Commercial, and Personal Lines units. The North American and International Commercial divisions, combined, produced net written premiums of $17.4 billion in 2025 (74% of total general insurance written premiums of $23.7 billion). Casualty lines of coverage accounted for 33% of 2025 commercial and international written premium volume. Property and short-tail lines of coverage equaled 27% of written premiums. Financial lines of coverage comprised 24% of net written premiums in 2025, while global specialty lines of coverage accounted for 16% of written premiums in 2025. AIG's global personal lines group primarily underwrites personal auto and homeowners' coverage and an array of personal accident and health insurance protection. Net written premiums totaled $6.25 billion in 2025 (26% of total firm-wide written premiums), of which global accident and health policies accounted for 39%, personal auto and homeowners for 46%, and other personal lines for the remaining 15% of 2025 global personal lines written premiums.

We view AIG as an undervalued franchise, and we believe AIG's ability to produce above-peer underwriting profitability as it navigates a more competitive market and lowers the risk profile of its book of business will provide its shares with a catalyst to close their valuation gap with peers. Our 12-month target price is $92, which assumes the shares will trade at 11.7x our 2026 operating EPS estimate and at 10.3x our 2027 operating EPS estimate. This compares to AIG's one-year average forward multiple of 11.4x and the p-c peer average of 13x-14x.

Chubb Limited (CB 324 ****), one of the world's leading publicly-traded p-c insurers, underwrites an array of commercial, personal property, and casualty insurance; personal accident and supplemental health insurance; reinsurance; and life insurance. P-c net written premiums totaled $54.8 billion in 2025, up 6.4% from $51.5 billion in 2024. Net earned premiums were also up by 6.4% to $53.0 billion in 2025 from $49.8 billion in 2024. Global p-c insurance accounted for 87% of net written premiums in 2025, while life insurance comprised the remaining 13% of net written premiums. Despite CB's global footprint, North America is still its primary market, accounting for over 60% of net written premiums in 2025, by our estimate. One of CB's key strengths is a solid underwriting track record, as measured by the combined (loss and expense) ratio. During 2025, the p-c combined ratio equaled 85.7%, an improvement from the 86.6% combined ratio reported in 2024, reflecting broadly based current accident-year claim trends and modestly improved underlying claim trends. The underlying combined ratio (which excludes catastrophes) improved to 81.9% in 2025 from 83.1% in 2024. These results remain superior to industry averages in both years.

We see CB benefiting from a flight to quality among underwriters amid an uncertain macroeconomic environment and a weakening but stable p-c pricing environment. We also believe CB's above-peer growth rate and underwriting profitability provide the shares with a catalyst to close their valuation gap to peers. We forecast net written premium growth in 2026 of 6% to 9%, versus the 7% rise in net written premiums in

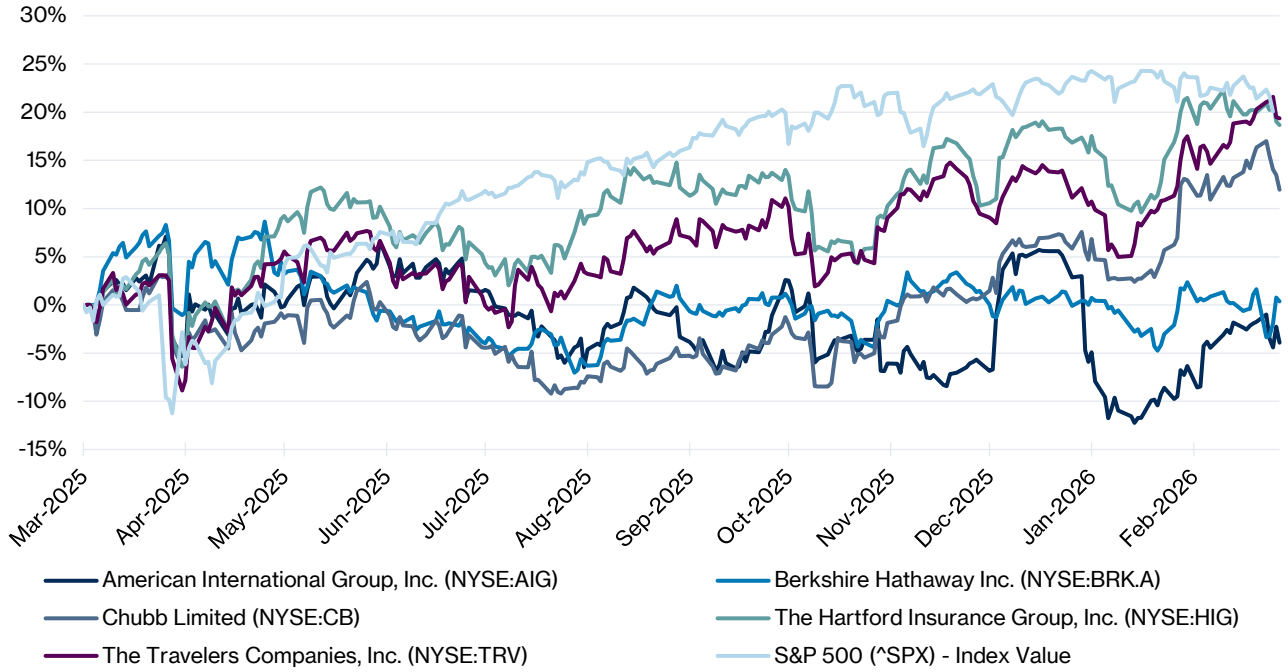
2025. Our 12-month target price is $380. We assume the shares will trade at a multiple of 14x our 2026 operating EPS estimate and at 13x our 2027 operating EPS estimate. These target multiples compare with a disparate peer average of 13x-14x (including some slower-growing firms that lack CB's market presence and balance sheet strength, as well as some faster-growing firms) and CB's three-year average forward multiple of 12x.

The Hartford Financial Services Group Inc. (HIG 138 ****) is a p-c insurer that undertook a comprehensive restructuring plan that is yielding results. HIG is focusing on its p-c, group benefits, and mutual fund businesses, and sold a number of non-core units in recent years. Segment core earnings (from continuing operations) totaled $3.95 billion in 2025, with Property Casualty Commercial and Personal Lines accounting for 80%, Group Benefits for 15%, and Mutual Funds for the remaining 5%. HIG's Property-Casualty Commercial Lines division generated earned premiums of $13.9 billion in 2025, versus $12.7 billion in 2024. Lines of coverage underwritten include workers' compensation, package business, commercial auto, general liability, property coverage, professional liability, and bond insurance. The commercial lines segment has three main units: Small Business (which accounted for 41% of the $14.5 billion in commercial net written premiums in 2025); Middle & Large Business (32%); and Global Specialty and Other (27%). The Personal Lines segment provides automobile and home-based coverages to individuals in the U.S., including a special program designed exclusively for members of AARP. We believe the shares are undervalued versus peers and have several attractive catalysts – an above-average rate of written premium growth, improved claims trends, and the benefits of a successful restructuring – that will enable HIG to close its valuation gap to peers. Our 12-month target price is $163, which assumes the shares will trade at 11.5x our 2026 operating EPS estimate of $14.20 and at 10.9x our 2027 operating EPS estimate of $14.95. These compare with HIG's one-year average forward multiple of 10.3x and a peer average of 13x-14x.

Berkshire Hathaway Inc. (BRK.B 497 ***) is an insurance-based conglomerate that produced segment operating earnings of $44.5 billion in 2025 (down 6.1% from $47.4 billion in 2024), derived from insurance premiums and investment income (44%); manufacturing, service, and retailing (31%); freight rail transportation revenues (12%); utility and energy revenues (9%); and other revenues (4%). BRK.B's insurance operations consist of GEICO (a leading auto insurer); BH Primary Group (an array of commercial lines insurers); and BH Reinsurance Group (reinsurance operations). Our Hold recommendation on the shares reflects our view that mixed/weakening fundamentals and the evaporation of the "Buffett premium" as BRK.B undergoes a significant management transition amid the retirement of Warren Buffett, removing a catalyst from the shares. Our 12-month target price of $520 assumes the shares will trade at 23.4x our 2026 operating EPS estimate and at 22x our 2027 operating EPS estimate. These multiples compare to BRK.B's three-year average forward multiple of 23x and are a premium to most insurance and reinsurance peers. This premium is warranted amid BRK.B's superior financial strength, in our view.

The Travelers Companies Inc. (TRV 303 ***) is a leading p-c insurance underwriter that produced written premiums of $44.4 billion in 2025, divided as follows: business insurance (51%), personal lines (39%), and bond and specialty insurance (10%). Business insurance net written premiums of $22.7 billion in 2025 were divided as follows: workers' compensation (15%), commercial multi-peril (26%), commercial auto (18%), general liability (16%), commercial property (16%), and international and other (9%). Underwriting results in this segment improved in 2025 on a stable level of catastrophe losses and more favorable prior-year loss development trends. We applaud TRV's risk management prowess, but we note the firm's mix of business is heavily weighted with slower-growing lines of business, like workers' compensation. We view TRV shares as fairly valued versus historical averages but worth holding. Our 12-month target price of $315 assumes the shares will trade at 12.3x our 2026 operating EPS estimate of $25.65 and at 11.4x our 2027 EPS estimate of $27.65, versus the shares' one-year average forward multiple of 11.5x.

Relative Performance



Source: S&P Global Market Intelligence. Data from March 10, 2025 to March 6, 2026.

Implications*

Positive implications: CFRA sees an improvement in company fundamentals, which could include (but are not limited to) improved pricing, strengthening backlog, market share gains, cost improvements, a more favorable regulatory environment, or improving demographic trends, over the next 12 months.

Negative implications: CFRA sees a weakening in the company's fundamentals, which could include (but are not limited to) weaker pricing, reduced backlog visibility, market share losses, cost inflation, unfavorable regulatory climate, or demographic headwinds, over the next 12 months.

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